

# THE GANDHIAN ERA

*South Africa • Return to India • First Satyagrahas*

Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi was the central figure of Indian politics from 1915 to 1947 — hence, "the Gandhian Era."

- Headings & Definitions   ● Explanations   ● Highlighter = Key Facts   🎯 Exam Tip   ✗ Common Mistake  
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## GANDHIJI — EARLY LIFE + THE JOURNEY TO SOUTH AFRICA

The period 1915 to 1947 is called the **Gandhian Era**, because Mahatma Gandhi was the central figure of the entire Indian political scene through this time. But his real political training ground lay years earlier — in **South Africa**.



### Basic Details

| Field      | Detail                           |
|------------|----------------------------------|
| Full Name  | Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi       |
| Born       | 2 October 1869                   |
| Birthplace | Porbandar, Kutch region, Gujarat |
| Father     | Karamchand Gandhi                |
| Mother     | Putlibai Gandhi                  |



#### Naming Convention

In Gujarat & Maharashtra, the father's name is placed in the middle — just like **Sachin Ramesh Tendulkar** (Ramesh = father's name). So: Mohandas **Karamchand**

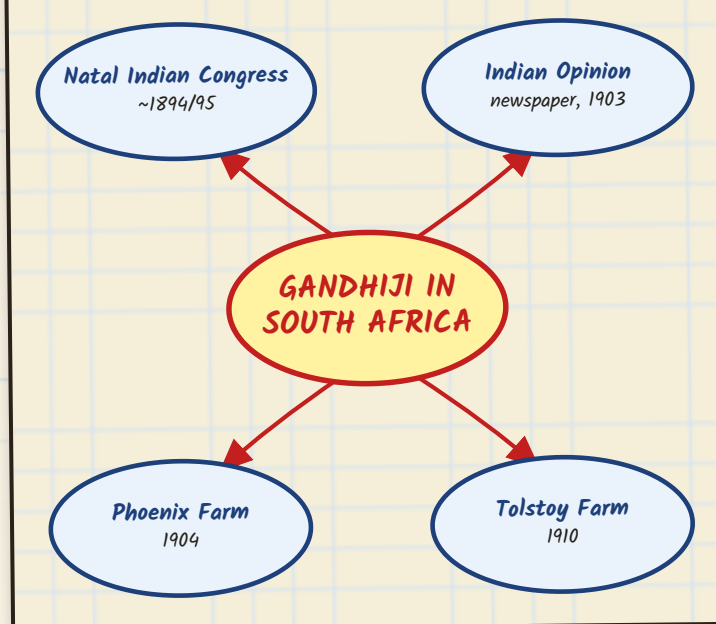
## Gandhi!

Gandhiji studied **law in England**. On returning, he came to **Bombay** — but could not establish a successful law practice there. Around this time, a client named **Abdullah**, a local merchant based in South Africa, had a legal case — and Gandhiji travelled to South Africa to handle it, roughly dated around **1898** (though, per the lecture, he had actually visited the region even earlier than this particular case). (Note: "Africa" here always means the country South Africa, not the whole continent.)

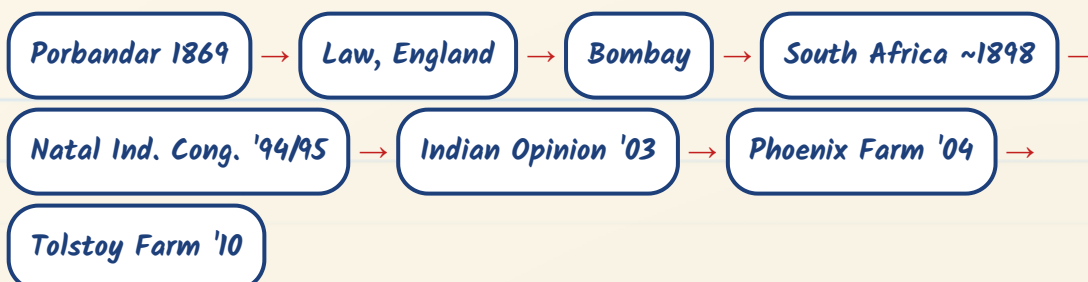
 Who was Abdullah? (tap to expand) ▼

It was in South Africa that Gandhiji first developed and used Satyagraha and the **hunger strike** — techniques he later brought to India after 1915.

 Fig 1: Gandhiji's Institutions in South Africa



## Institutions, Timeline & Influences



- Founded the **Natal Indian Congress** — a protest against the racial discrimination faced by Indians/Asians in South Africa
- Published the **Indian Opinion** newspaper, started in 1903
- Wrote **Hind Swaraj** during his South Africa years
- Established **Phoenix Farm** in 1904
- Established **Tolstoy Farm** in 1910 — deeply influenced by **Leo Tolstoy** and **John Ruskin**
- Developed the new technique of **Satyagraha** on these farms, inspired by John Ruskin's book "Unto This Last."

### ✗ Common Mistake

Phoenix Farm (1904) and Tolstoy Farm (1910) are often swapped in exams — **Phoenix came first**, Tolstoy Farm **six years later!**



### Memory Trick

"P before T, 4 before 10" — **Phoenix Farm (1904)** comes before **Tolstoy Farm (1910)**.



### Exam Tip

Order to remember: Natal Indian Congress (~'94/95) → Indian Opinion (1903) → Phoenix Farm (1904) → Tolstoy Farm (1910) — the dates only move forward!

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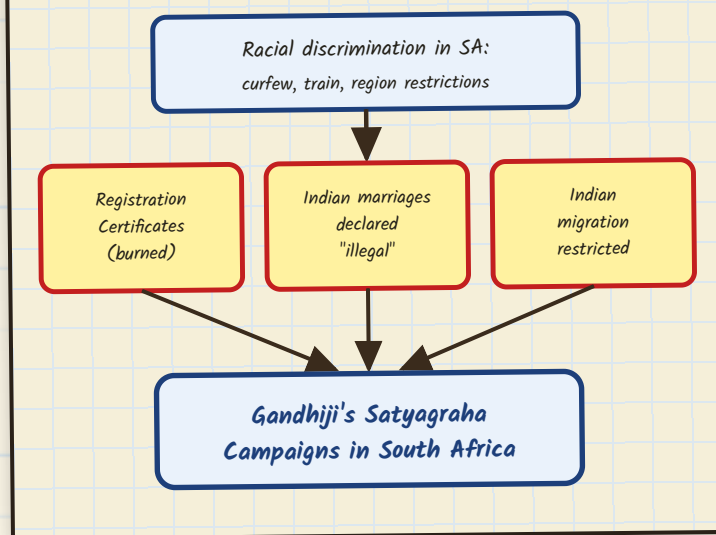
## RACIAL DISCRIMINATION + THREE SATYAGRAHA CAMPAIGNS

Discrimination against Asians (mainly Indians) in South Africa was **rampant**. Consider what Indians/Asians actually faced there:

- Asians were not allowed to go out after 9:00 p.m. — only white South Africans could move about safely at night
- Asians were confined to specific regions; they could not live anywhere else
- Asians could not board the **first-class compartment** on trains

Gandhiji himself experienced this: travelling on the Natal route with a valid **first-class ticket**, he was still thrown out of the first-class compartment by an officer, simply because he was Asian.

Fig 2: Discrimination → Three Satyagraha Campaigns



### The Three Campaigns (all fought in South Africa)

1. **Satyagraha against Registration Certificates** — every Indian/Asian had to carry a registration certificate (like today's Aadhaar card); without it, one could be jailed. Gandhiji led a Satyagraha here and **publicly burned** such certificates.
2. **Campaign against Indian marriages being declared illegal** — the British declared any Indian marriage not conducted according to Christian religious custom as illegal.
3. **Campaign against restriction of Indian migration** — Indians were not allowed to freely migrate from one place to another.

Registration Certificates



Marriages "illegal"



Migration restricted



Understand it like this...

The registration certificate worked just like today's **Aadhaar card** — compulsory to carry, and if you didn't have one, you could be jailed. Gandhiji's response? Burn the certificates in public, in full view of the authorities!

 **Gandhiji's Ideological Roots** (tap to expand) ▼

### Exam Tip

All three campaigns — Registration Certificates, Marriage Legality, Migration Restriction — happened in **South Africa**, not India. A favourite exam trap!

### Common Mistake

Don't assume Satyagraha began in India! Gandhiji tested it **first in South Africa** — against registration certificates, marriage laws, and migration restrictions — and only brought it to India after 1915.

### Memory Trick

Remember "**R-M-M**" for the three South Africa campaigns: **R**egistration certificates, **M**arriages (declared illegal), **M**igration (restricted).

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## **RETURN TO INDIA + THE ROAD TO 1917**

Gandhiji arrived in India on **9 January 1915** — a date now celebrated as **Pravasi Bharatiya Divas** (NRI Day). But he did not enter the political scene directly.



### Fun Fact

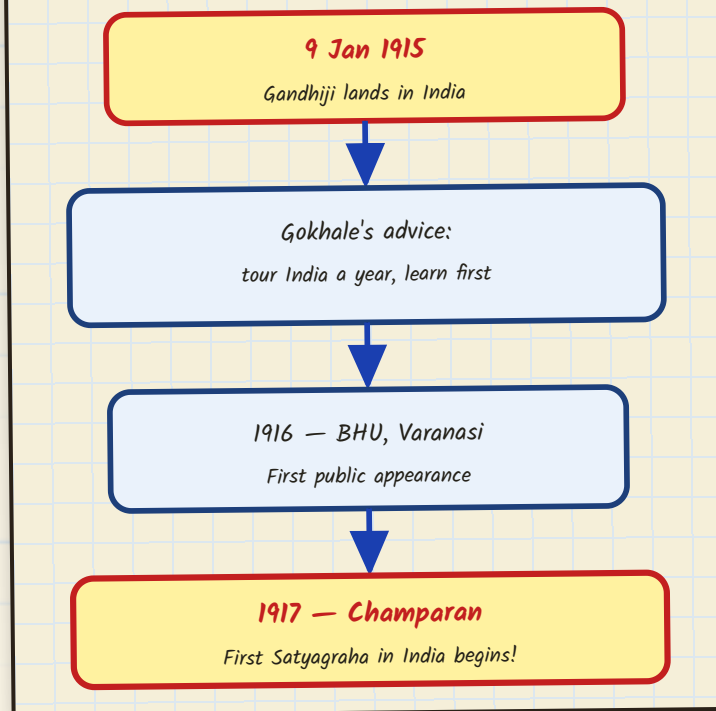
9 January is celebrated every year as **Pravasi Bharatiya Divas** — precisely because this is the day Gandhiji returned to India from South Africa in 1915!

### **Gokhale's Advice**

Gopal Krishna Gokhale, Gandhiji's political guru, advised him *not* to get directly involved in any movement or Satyagraha right away. Instead: first travel across India for a year, and learn about the country.

 Gopal Krishna Gokhale (tap to expand) ▼

 Fig 3: From Arrival to First Movement



● 9 Jan 1915

Gandhiji arrives in India from South Africa.

● Gopal Krishna Gokhale advises him to tour India for a year and learn about it first, rather than jumping into a movement.

! ● 1916

Gandhiji's **first public appearance** — at the inauguration of **Banaras Hindu University (BHU)**, founded by **Madan Mohan Malaviya**.

● 1917

Gandhiji launches his **first movement in India** — the **Champaran Satyagraha**.



9 JAN 1915 → 1917: two years of learning before the first movement!

## Key People

| Person                | Role                                                                           |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Gopal Krishna Gokhale | Political guru; founded Servants of India Society (1905); also Jinnah's mentor |
| Madan Mohan Malaviya  | Founder of BHU; university inaugurated in 1916                                 |

(Note: some accounts also mention Gandhiji's presence at the Indian National Congress session of 1901 as an early appearance, though he launched no movement until 1917.)



### Exam Tip

Gandhiji arrived on 9 Jan 1915 but his first movement came only in 1917 — a full **two-year gap** of learning India first, exactly as Gokhale advised!



### Common Mistake

Don't assume Gandhiji jumped straight into a movement on arrival! His first **public appearance** was BHU in 1916; his first **movement** (Champaran) was only in 1917 — two different milestones.



### Memory Trick

"Go-khale said Go and see India first!" — a quick way to remember Gokhale's advice to tour the country before acting.



# CHAMPARAN SATYAGRAHA — GANDHIJI'S FIRST SATYAGRAHA IN INDIA

Between 1917 and 1918, Gandhiji led three important movements back-to-back. The first was the **Champaran Satyagraha**, in 1917 — his very first Satyagraha in India.

## Why Champaran?

Champaran is in **Bihar**. Farmers here were forced to cultivate **indigo** on at least 3/20th of their land — a system called **Tinkathia** ("Tinkathia" literally means 3/20th).

- By the late 1890s, cheap **German synthetic dyes** had flooded the market — factory-made, and far cheaper than natural indigo
- Natural indigo grown by British planters could no longer compete, or cover costs, in the European market
- So the British forcibly declared that farmers *must* cultivate indigo on part of their land — the Tinkathia system



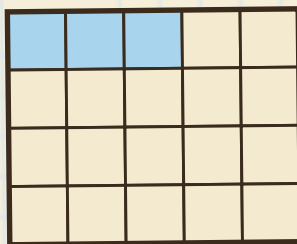
### Did you know?

This wasn't the only indigo-related revolt worth remembering — an earlier **Indigo uprising of 1859** had already begun in the **Nadia district of West Bengal**. And in the Champaran Satyagraha, we see early glimpses of the kind of civil disobedience that would later define the full **Civil Disobedience Movement of 1930**.



Fig 4: The Tinkathia System

One Farmer's Land = 20 "Kathas"



**TINKATHIA = 3/20 kathas**

forced indigo cultivation (blue)

remaining 17/20 = farmer's own crop



German dyes cheap



Natural indigo unprofitable



Tinkathia forced (3/20 land)

## Champaran Agrarian Act – What Changed

| Before                                                                                   | After the Act    |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| Tinkathia (forced indigo on 3/20th land)                                                 | <b>Abolished</b> |
| Abwab (extra taxes: house tax, grazing tax, irrigation tax — imposed since Mughal times) | <b>Suspended</b> |

 What exactly was Abwab? (tap to expand) ▼

## People Involved in Champaran

| Person          | Note                                                                                                 |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Mahatma Gandhi  | Led the Satyagraha                                                                                   |
| Rajendra Prasad | Participant; later independent India's <b>first President</b>                                        |
| Mazharul Haq    | Participant                                                                                          |
| J. B. Kripalani | Participant; later moved India's <b>first no-confidence motion</b> (against Nehru — it did not pass) |

### Exam Tip

Champaran (1917) = Gandhiji's **first Satyagraha** in India — but it was *not* an all-India movement, only limited to Bihar!

### Common Mistake

Tinkathia ≠ Abwab! **Tinkathia** = forced indigo cultivation on 3/20th of land. **Abwab** = extra taxes (house/grazing/irrigation) beyond the normal tax. The Champaran Agrarian Act dealt with both, separately.

### Memory Trick

"Tin-kathia" → think of the number **3** ("teen" in Hindi) out of **20** — forced indigo on 3/20th of the land!

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## AHMEDABAD MILL STRIKE, KHEDA + BARDOLI SATYAGRAHA

### Ahmedabad Mill Strike (1918) — First Hunger Strike

The First World War (1914–1918) had pushed up prices sharply — even though the British-led Allied Powers won the war, the cost to Britain was enormous, and the effects of inflation were felt directly in India too.



- Mill workers demanded a **50%** wage increase, in line with inflation
- Mill owners offered only **20%**
- **Anusuya Sarabhai** — sister of mill owner **Ambalal Sarabhai** — invited Gandhiji to Ahmedabad in **1918**
- This became Gandhiji's first hunger strike



Anusuya & Ambalal Sarabhai (tap to expand) ▼



#### Fun Fact

Anusuya Sarabhai sided with the mill **workers**, even though her own brother Ambalal Sarabhai was one of the mill **owners** she was up against!

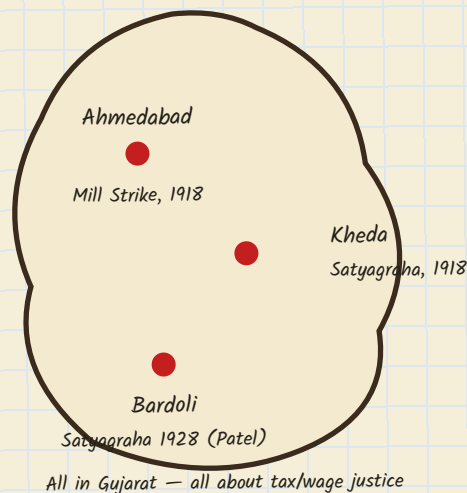
### Kheda Satyagraha (1918) — First Non-Cooperation Movement

Kheda is in **Gujarat**. Under British rule, farmers had to pay land revenue — but if their produce fell below **one-fourth** of the normal amount, no revenue was payable at all.

- Crop failure (drought) meant many farmers' produce fell well below the taxable threshold
- Farmers demanded a full waiver of that year's revenue
- The British insisted normal production had occurred, and refused any waiver
- Gandhiji led the Kheda Satyagraha in support of these farmers

This is considered Gandhiji's first Non-Cooperation Movement.

Fig 5: Gujarat – Where It All Happened



### Bardoli Satyagraha (1928)

Bardoli, also in Gujarat, saw a similar land-tax Satyagraha in 1928 — but this one was not led by Gandhiji. It was led by **Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel**, who earned the title "Sardar" here, bestowed on him by the women participants of the movement.

### Gandhiji's Movements – The "Firsts"

| Movement              | Year | Place   | Known As                        |
|-----------------------|------|---------|---------------------------------|
| Champaran Satyagraha  | 1917 | Bihar   | First Satyagraha in India       |
| Ahmedabad Mill Strike | 1918 | Gujarat | First hunger strike             |
| Kheda Satyagraha      | 1918 | Gujarat | First Non-Cooperation Movement  |
| Bardoli Satyagraha    | 1928 | Gujarat | Led by Sardar Patel, not Gandhi |

Champaran '17

Ahmedabad '18

Kheda '18

Bardoli '28



CGL Mains asked: "Which was Gandhiji's first Satyagraha AND first hunger strike?" – options included Champaran, Ahmedabad, Kheda & the Rowlatt Satyagraha.

The honest answer is actually **both** Champaran and Ahmedabad – Champaran (limited to Bihar, not an all-India movement) was the first Satyagraha, while the Ahmedabad Mill Strike was the first hunger strike.



#### Exam Tip

Three "firsts" to learn together: **Champaran** = first Satyagraha, **Ahmedabad** = first hunger strike, **Kheda** = first Non-Cooperation Movement.



#### Common Mistake

Bardoli Satyagraha (1928) was *not* led by Gandhiji – it was **Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel** who led it, earning his title "Sardar" there!



#### Memory Trick

Remember the order **A-K-B**: **Ahmedabad** (1918, wages) → **Kheda** (1918, land tax) → **Bardoli** (1928, land tax, Patel).



### Exam-Ready Summary

- **Gandhian Era:** 1915–1947
- **South Africa institutions:** Natal Indian Congress ('94/95), Indian Opinion (1903), Phoenix Farm (1904), Tolstoy Farm (1910)
- **Three South Africa campaigns:** Registration Certificates, Marriages, Migration
- **Arrival in India:** 9 January 1915 (Pravasi Bharatiya Divas)
- **First movement in India:** Champaran Satyagraha (1917)
- **First hunger strike:** Ahmedabad Mill Strike (1918)
- **First Non-Cooperation Movement:** Kheda Satyagraha (1918)
- **Bardoli Satyagraha (1928):** led by Sardar Patel, not Gandhiji

